

God's Word says, "For this cause a man shall leave his father and his mother, and shall cleave to his wife; and they shall become one flesh" (Genesis 2:24). In other words, a married couple becomes one person. Two personalities merge together in a marriage to operate as one. The extremes of one person are balanced by the partner's extremes.

Quite often, single people live lives of extremes. They are frequently classic examples of imbalanced lifestyles. And even within the same family, their personalities are totally different. My wife and I raised four children—all different. When our oldest son was growing up, you could go into his room and know exactly what he was like. It was clean; his bed was made; the books were in order on his desk.

If you went into our other son's room, you had to carry a stick with you because there were things that lived under his bed. As you might guess, when they get married, they will marry girls who will help to balance their extremes. Indeed, our oldest son is now married and has two children. He still straightens some, but he's learned to relax and tolerate some clutter. His wife is an excellent balance to his personality because she is as outgoing as he is shy.

If sloppy singles never got married, they would have to always buy new clothes, because they would never wash the old ones! Without balance and accountability, extremes are the norm. A God-based marriage is two people willing to totally merge their lives as partners to utilize their strengths. That's called balance, and that's what a marriage should be. In the area of finances, balance is especially critical. "An excellent wife, who can find? For her worth is far more than jewels. The heart of her husband trusts in her, and he will have no lack of gain" (Proverbs 31:10-11).

4 GOD'S MINIMUM STANDARDS

God's Word provides standards for managing money that are essential for marital oneness. One of the things I find in coun-